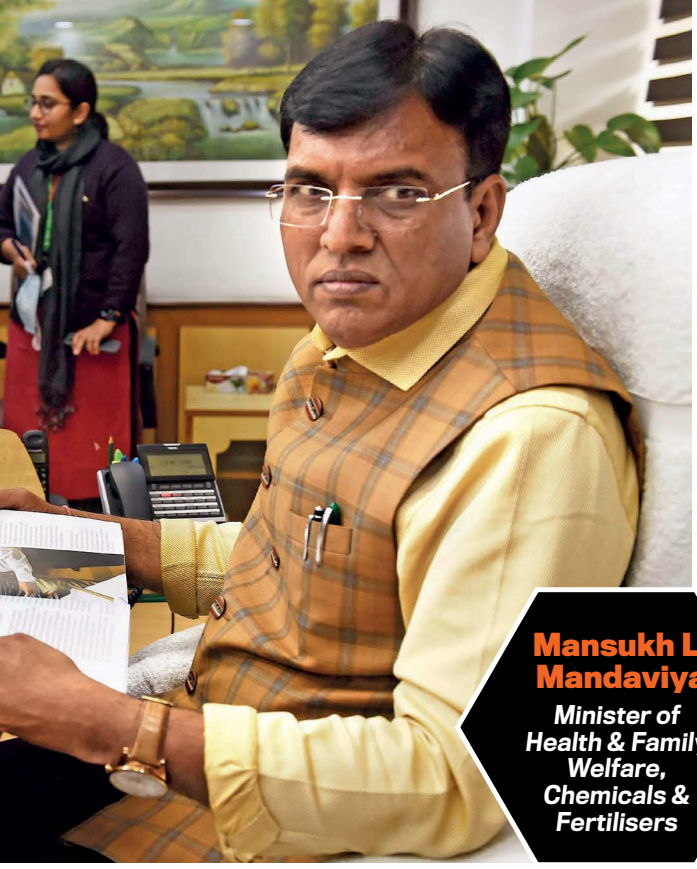


Mansukh L. Mandaviya
Minister of Health & Family Welfare, Chemicals & Fertilisers

make up for the time lost to Covid, an intensive immunisation programme was held from February to May 2022, which saw the vaccination of nearly 6 million children and 1.5 million pregnant women.

Other health indexes have also improved. India has already achieved the MMR (maternal mortality ratio) of less than 100/lakh live births. Institutional deliveries and skilled birth attendant deliveries are nearly 90 per cent at the moment. Infant mortality has also declined. According to SRS (Sample Registration System) 2021, the IMR in 2019 was at 30 per lakh live births, down from 32 in 2018. As a result of improved awareness and accessibility to family planning methods, India has also achieved a replacement rate of 2 for its population.

When it comes to diseases, MoHFW's biggest achievement of the past four years has been in tuberculosis detection and treatment. Designated microscopy centres (DMCs) have increased by 61 per cent (23,028 in 2022) over the past nine years while 4,700-plus new molecular diagnostic laboratories have also come up. To further improve detection, door-to-door campaigns and mobile TB detection units were active in remote areas. As a result, in 2021, India was able to notify 18 per cent more TB cases as compared to 2020. That same year also saw nearly 700,000 notifications from the private sector, the highest ever. The government has also made available two critical drugs—bedaquiline and delamanid—for the treatment of multi-drug resistant TB. To further improve treatment outcomes, a nutrition scheme has been introduced, which supports patients with Rs 500 per month for the entire duration of their treatment. As a result, in 2021, the treatment success rate went up to 84 per cent. ■

CHEMICALS & FERTILISERS

Aatmanirbhar Pharma

Reducing India's import dependency in pharma and handling the fertiliser crisis have been the ministry's chief preoccupations this term

By Himanshu Shekhar

FOR LONG DEPENDENT ON IMPORTS of key starting materials (KSM), active pharmaceutical ingredients (API) and medical devices, the Rs 25,000 crore PLI scheme for pharma, bulk drugs and medical devices could well be turning the tide. Fifty-one projects for APIs, 26 for medical devices and another 55 for pharma have got approval so far with investments of Rs 22,000 crore. A National Medical Device Policy, 2023, was also approved in April.

The battle has been different on the fertilisers front, courtesy Russian aggression in Ukraine. India began to feel the pinch as the West imposed sanctions on Russia, one of our top suppliers of fertiliser components urea and potash. Deals with supplier countries like Saudi Arabia, Morocco and Jordan helped avert the crisis and ensure record harvests in FY23. Looking back at the crisis, minister Mansukh Mandaviya says, "It was clear from day one that we had to protect our farmers and the agri sector from global market uncertainties. We could not afford any disruption in food production. We ensured uninterrupted supply of fertilisers at the best possible price through long-term agreements. At home, we increased subsidy." ■

BOLD & BRAVE

₹25,000 CRORE
worth PLI schemes for pharma eased import dependency

Navigated fertiliser crisis fallout of Russia-Ukraine war

"IT WAS CLEAR FROM DAY ONE THAT WE HAD TO PROTECT OUR FARMERS.... WE ENSURED UNINTERRUPTED SUPPLY OF FERTILISERS AT THE BEST POSSIBLE PRICE"
–MANSUKH MANDAVIYA